

## The culture of action research in Saudi Arabia schools from English teachers' perceptions

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## **The culture of action research in Saudi Arabia schools from English teachers' perceptions**

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**Abstract:** This study investigated the culture of action research from the perspectives of English language teachers in Saudi Arabia. To achieve this aim, the descriptive design was used. The sample consisted of (43) teachers, and data were collected through a questionnaire designed to examine their perceptions of the school culture related to action research, the frequency of their engagement in such practices, and the underlying reasons for limited participation. The findings indicated that, although teachers generally held positive views regarding the institutional culture of action research, the actual implementation was infrequent or absent for many participants. The analysis revealed several significant barriers, most notably the lack of engagement from colleagues and time constraints. These findings underscore the importance of addressing these challenges in order to promote practical engagement with action research in the field of English language teaching (ELT).

**Keywords:** action research-research engagement- ELT

## Introduction

One of the major factors in solving teaching problems is conducting action research. It is an approach that is progressively offered as part of continuous professional development (Edwards & Burns, 2016); moreover, many nations' educational systems offer action research a prominent place. The primary justification for this truth is that it is useful for enhancing classroom instruction (Worku et al., 2022). Burns (2013) sees action research as a means of empowering teachers and enabling them to acquire deeper insights and understanding of their practices through a systematic approach that brings together classroom action, research, and reflection.

The teachers emphasized several advantages of conducting action research, including professional development, improved teaching practices, enhanced classroom learning outcomes, and increased pedagogical competence. It empowers teachers to assess their teaching methods, reflect on student performance, and generate practical ways to enhance their skills (Bongcayao, 2023).

The literature has seen a growth in language teacher research engagement through empirical investigations (e.g., Anwaruddin & Pervin, 2015; Borg, 2013; Borg & Liu, 2013; Borg, 2009; Banegas, 2018). However, only a limited number of empirical studies of English teachers' conceptions of action research exist (Tabatabaei and Nazim, 2013; Doqaruni et al., 2019; Al-Obaydi et al., 2021). Therefore, the purpose of this study is to explore the culture of action research from English teachers' perceptions in Saudi Arabia schools.

## Study questions

The study was centered on the following three research questions in accordance with the previously specified purpose:

1. What are EFL teachers' perceptions of their school culture in relation to action research?
2. To what extent do teachers engage in action research?
3. What are their reasons for not doing action research?

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### **The importance of the study**

The study is expected to be significant for offer new insights to stakeholders how teachers perceive and define research, which is crucial for promoting teacher action research engagement. This study will make teachers aware of the importance of conducting action research and the challenges the will face. In addition, it is assisting decision-makers in Saudi Arabia to have better understanding of the status and obstacles related to action research practice. The findings can help in developing informed policies to promote teacher research engagement in the field of English language teaching.

Finally, the present study is expected to open the way for researchers and those interested in English language curricula in particular and curricula in general to conduct similar studies that contribute to the development of teaching practices.

### **Literature review**

#### **Action research**

Burns (2009) mentions that ‘action’ in action research refers to the improvement of an existing practice in specific social contexts (such as a classroom or school) in order to bring about change, whereas ‘research’ refers to the systematic investigation and study of the change that results from such action.

From an educational perspective, McNiff and Whitehead (2002, p. 15) state that the term “action research” refers to “a practical way of looking at your own work to check that it is as you would like it to be.”

In addition, Workuet al. (2022) defined action research as a systematic method of identifying issues that affect teaching and learning, comprehending the complexity of those issues, and ultimately resolving issues and enhancing practices through action plans developed, put into practice, and assessed.

Experts and academic researchers have historically created and carried out teacher professional development programs through workshops, college-level courses, and in-service training initiatives. However, professional development is more about

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the daily cultivation of learning habits than it is about seminars and courses (Vulla, 2013).

Many studies have highlighted the importance of conducting action research to develop teachers' practices. For instance, Crooks (1993) argued that action research supports the process of teacher reflection, which is the key to professional growth. To make a transition from teacher to teacher-researcher, instructors need information and advice about how to perform action research, according to a number of studies (Borg, 2013; Burns, 2000; Burton, 1997). It's critical that educators have access to mentors who can offer advice (Burns, 2017). One suggestion is for managers to speak with nearby institutions or teacher training programs to promote partnerships (Yuan & Lee, 2015).

Through action research, teachers developed an inquiry stance as part of their professional learning, which led to: enhanced pedagogical knowledge and skills, new insights into teaching and learning, better understanding of their roles as teachers, increased self-awareness of skills and areas for improvement, and changed conceptions of teaching and learning (Rumiantsev, et al, 2024).

Even though more extensive and complex descriptions of the steps in AR have been suggested (e.g., Burns 1999; Cohen, Manion, and Morrison 2000; Hopkins 1993; McNiff 1988), the most well-known model is that of Kemmis and McTaggart (1988):

- Develop a plan of critically informed action to improve what is already happening,
- Act to implement the plan,
- Observe the effects of the critically informed action in the context in which it occurs, and
- Reflect on these effects as a basis for further planning, subsequent critically informed action, and so on, through a succession of cycles.



He added that action research consists of four phases: planning, acting, observing, and reflecting. These four processes are to be seen as parts of the dynamic process of action research rather than as static steps that stand alone.

To conduct action research school culture should be prepared. Patterson, et al (1986) emphasize that school culture plays a vital role in shaping student behavior and achievement, though classroom and individual student factors may have a stronger influence. They point out that school culture is not something that simply exists on its own—it is created by the people within the school, meaning it can also be intentionally shaped or changed. While schools may share certain cultural traits, each school's culture is inherently unique and should reflect its own identity. A strong, well-defined culture can unify a school community and give clear direction to its mission. However, school culture can also hinder progress if it becomes a barrier to learning or perpetuates discrimination against particular student groups. Therefore, any meaningful and lasting changes in areas like teaching methods or leadership structures require a deep understanding of the existing culture and often a deliberate effort to change it—something that takes time and careful attention.

### **Action research in English language field**

Some research on English teachers' engagement in action research has been conducted. For example, to explore the current level of teachers' involvement in action research and to determine the difficulties they face as well as the potential opportunities, Worku et al. (2022) conducted a study in primary schools in Bahir Dar city; a mixed-methods research approach was employed. The data was gathered from a sample of 251 primary school teachers. The results of the study indicated that the teachers' engagement in action research within the primary schools of the city was significantly low. Moreover, the lack of sufficient training, excessive teaching workload, and absence of incentives were identified as the most significant challenges faced by these educators.

Al-Obaydi et al. (2021), who studied this issue in Indonesia, concluded that student-teachers have positive perceptions towards using action research in teaching

English. In addition, Doqaruni et al. (2019) conducted a mixed-methods study to explore the extent to which Iranian teachers do action research and the reasons for not doing research. The participants were 65 English teachers. They found that the three main reasons for not doing action research were a lack of time, not having enough knowledge and support, and finally, teachers thought that their job was only teaching.

Banegas (2018) investigated the perspectives on research embraced by English as a foreign language (EFL) teachers in Argentina. The research design involved gathering quantitative data through an online questionnaire distributed to 622 participants. Additionally, qualitative data were obtained through online interviews conducted with 40 of these participants. The findings indicated that the teachers did not consider research as an integral aspect of their profession, and a major obstacle to their limited engagement with research was the lack of time.

Edwards & Burns (2016) conducted a study in Australia about the sustainability of the impact of action research. The sample consisted of 33 English teachers. After completing an AR programme, data from a survey and interviews showed that the teachers experienced a heightened sense of assurance and established stronger bonds with their students. Additionally, they actively pursued research projects and received acknowledgment from both their peers and superiors.

The reviewed studies collectively provide a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of English teachers' engagement in action research (AR) across various contexts. Several key themes emerge, including the level of engagement, challenges, perceptions, and benefits of participation in AR. The studies used mixed-methods approaches (Worku et al., 2022; Doqaruni et al., 2019), large-scale surveys (Banegas, 2018), and interviews (Edwards & Burns, 2016) to collect data. Multiple studies (e.g., Worku et al., 2022; Doqaruni et al., 2019; Banegas, 2018) consistently highlight that teacher engagement in action research is generally low, regardless of geographical context. Interestingly, Al-Obaydi et al. (2021) present a more optimistic view, noting that student-teachers in Indonesia hold positive attitudes toward using AR in English teaching.

According to the literature review—up to now—there have been no attempts to examine the culture of action research from English teachers' perceptions in Saudi Arabia

## Method

The design of this study followed a quantitative method. This method focuses on examining social and natural events and providing an accurate description of them. This is accomplished by gathering information and data through surveys, responding to research questions, analyzing the data, and then quantitatively summarizing the findings (Davies & Hughes, 2014).

## Participants

Questionnaire data were collected from a sample of 43 teachers of the English language in the Taif district. Tables 1 and 2 show the sample according to the training sessions in action research and qualifications relevant to ELT, respectively.

**Table 1 Respondents by number of courses**

| Training sessions | N (%)     |
|-------------------|-----------|
| No one            | 31(72.1)  |
| One               | 10 (23.3) |
| More than one     | 2 (4.7)   |
| Total             | 43 (100)  |

The table 1 presents data on the number of training sessions attended by participants, in relation to action research. The majority of participants (72.1%) have not received any training. Only 23.3% of the respondents have attended one training session, and a very small proportion, just 4.7%, have had more than one training session.



**Table 2 Respondents by ELT qualification**

| qualification | N (%)     |
|---------------|-----------|
| Bachelor's    | 29 (67.4) |
| High studies  | 14 (32.6) |
| Total         | 43 (100)  |

The table 3 presents data on the educational qualifications of 43 participants. The majority (67.4%) of the participants hold a Bachelor's degree. Only 32.6% have pursued higher studies (which include Master's or above).

**Instrument**The data were collected through an online questionnaire. The online questionnaire was completed by 43 EFL teachers in the Taif district of Saudi Arabia between June and October 2023.

The format of the questionnaire used in this study is generally based on the questionnaire developed by Borg (2009). Borg's questionnaire originally had six sections, two of which (sections 3-5) were used in this particular study due to their relevance (see Appendix). However, all instances of the word "research" in sections 3-5 of the original questionnaire were changed to "action research" to reflect the aims of the present study. Section 3 contained 9 items about teachers' opinions on action research in schools, and the items were measured on a 5-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 = disagree strongly to 5 = agree strongly. Section 5's first question was measured on a 4-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 = never to 4 = often. If a respondent does action research rarely or never, they go straight to question 2, which contained 10 items about the reasons for not doing action research, and the items were measured using a dichotomous scale with options of "yes" or "no."

### **validity and Reliability**

The study tool was presented in its initial form to a number of specialists to express their opinion on the questionnaire phrases in terms of the construction of the phrases, their clarity, and the correctness of the linguistic formulation. After taking their opinions into account, the tool became in its final form ready for application.

For reliability the researcher computed Cronbach's Alpha using SPSS to assess the survey's internal consistency, and the results showed that it was 0.73. The values indicated strong dependability because they were over 0.70 (Cohen et al. 2013).

## The result

This part presents the data analysis based on research questions:

1- What are EFL teachers' perceptions of their school culture in relation to action research?

Descriptive statistics were applied to obtain percentages to measure EFL teachers' perceptions of action research culture in their schools, as shown in Table 3

**Table 3 EFL Teachers' Perceptions About Action Research**

| Items                                                                   | Disagree Strongly | Disagree | Do Not Know | Agree | Agree Strongly |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|----------|-------------|-------|----------------|
| 1. Teachers do action research themselves.                              | 11.6              | 9.3      | 20.9        | 37.2  | 20.9           |
| 2. The management encourages teachers to do research.                   | 23.3              | 32.6     | 16.3        | 11.6  | 16.3           |
| 3. Teachers feel that doing research is an important part of their job. | 11.6              | 25.6     | 18.6        | 32.6  | 11.6           |
| 4. Teachers have access to research books and journals.                 | 9.3               | 18.6     | 7           | 39.5  | 25.6           |
| 5. Teachers have opportunities to learn about current research.         | 9.3               | 11.6     | 14          | 34.9  | 30.2           |
| 6. Teachers talk about action research.                                 | 39.5              | 32.6     | 25.6        | 2.3   | 0              |
| 7. Teachers are given support to attend ELT conferences.                | 34.9              | 14       | 20.9        | 25.6  | 4.7            |
| 8. Time for doing research is built into teachers' workloads.           | 46.5              | 34.9     | 4.7         | 7     | 7              |
| 9. Teachers read published action research.                             | 14                | 44.2     | 23.2        | 16.3  | 2.3            |

As Table 3 shows the EFL teachers' perceptions about action research in their schools, they agreed and strongly agreed that "Teachers have access to research books and journals" (39.5%) and (25.6%), followed by "Teachers have opportunities to learn about current research" (34.9%) and (30.2%), respectively, representing "agree strongly" and "agree." A similar pattern was seen in Item 1, where (37.2%) and (20.9%) of the participants agreed that "Teachers do action research themselves." On the other hand, they strongly disagreed and disagreed that "Time for doing research is built into teachers' workloads" (46.5%) and (34.9%), followed by "Teachers talk about action research" (39.5%), then "Teachers are given support to attend ELT conferences" (34.9%), and finally, "The management encourages teachers to do research" (23.3%) and (32.6%), respectively, representing "disagree strongly" and "disagree." This means that more than half of the participants have a negative attitude about school management in favor of supporting action research.

## 2- To what extent do teachers say they do action research?

Frequency and percentage were employed to explore how often teachers do action research, as shown in Table 4.

**Table 4 Doing Action Research**

| item                  | always  | sometime  | rarely    | never     |
|-----------------------|---------|-----------|-----------|-----------|
| Doing action research | 2 (4.7) | 10 (23.3) | 10 (23.3) | 21 (48.8) |

Table 4 revealed that of the total participants, only (4.7%) said they did action research, (23.3%) of the respondents said they did AR sometimes, while (48.8%) of individuals reported never doing research and (23.3%) rarely. As shown, the 'never' option received the highest percentage among the other options.

## 3- What are their Reasons for not Doing Action Research?

Teachers who reported conducting action research rarely or never (N = 31) were asked to indicate their reasons for not doing so by selecting items from a list provided. The findings are summarized in Table 5.

**Table 5 Teachers' Reasons for Not Doing Action Research**

| Reasons for Not Doing Action Research                                  | Frequency (%) |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|
| 1) I do not know enough about action research methods.                 | 24 (77.4)     |
| 2) My job is to teach not to do action research.                       | 21 (67.7)     |
| 3) I do not have time to do action research.                           | 25 (80.6)     |
| 4) My employer discourages it.                                         | 21 (67.7)     |
| 5) I am not interested in doing action research.                       | 17 (54.8)     |
| 6) I need someone to advise me, but no one is available.               | 25 (80.6)     |
| 7) Most of my colleagues do not do action research.                    | 28 (90.3)     |
| 8) I do not have access to the books and journals I need.              | 15 (48.4)     |
| 9) The learners would not cooperate if I did action research in class. | 17 (54.8)     |
| 10) Other teachers would not cooperate if I asked for their help.      | 20 (64.5)     |

As can be seen from the table above, a majority of participants (90.3%) stated that the most common reason for not doing action research was that most of their colleagues do not do it; the next reasons were a lack of time and not finding an advisor. A lack of knowledge about action research was the next factor on this list. A number of the teachers (67.7%) who indicated they do action research rarely or never said that such activity was not their primary responsibility because they were teachers, not researchers, while only 15% of them said they did not have access to different research resources.

## Discussion

In response to the first research question regarding EFL teachers' perceptions of their school culture concerning action research in Saudi Arabia, this study found that EFL teachers have a negative perception of the culture of action research in their schools, as Borg (2008) mentioned that the teachers do not feel their schools encourage research cultures. For example, in this study, more than half of the teachers perceive that the management doesn't encourage them to do research. This finding is consistent

with that of Tabatabaei and Nazim (2013) and Banegas (2018), who argued that there is a lack of support from institutions to the teacher despite their ability to conduct action research. Moreover, they don't provide support to attend ELT conferences; this finding supports the work of Banegas (2018); however, it contradicts Borg (2007) because the sample of teachers was working at a university. This result might be due to school managers thinking action research is not one of the main responsibilities of teachers and that they have to focus on achieving lesson plans and students' learning outcomes. The key finding was that 81.4% disagreed that time for research is built into their workload. This view is reflected in the reasons for not doing action research. This result aligns with Borg (2007) and Barker (2005), who argued that time is a factor that has a greater impact than others on the level of actual participation in research and that systems need to be built into institutions.

In contrast, English teachers believe that they can access research books and journals and learn about current research. This finding was also reported by Borg (2007). It is possible that these results are due to the digital revolution and the internet. In addition, the Ministry of Education allows teachers to read and download research freely from the Saudi Digital Library.

The result of the second question indicated that although teachers feel that doing research is an important part of their job, the majority of English teachers never conduct action research. Our study supports prior findings by Doqaruni et al. (2019) and Alrwais et al. (2020). This is because they don't read published action research or attend ELT conferences, so they have insufficient knowledge about action research.

This study has also identified a number of reasons why English teachers said they do not conduct action research. Most of their colleagues do not do action research, and they didn't have an advisor to help them; maintaining research was an important factor. Borg (2009) refers to the influence peers can have on teachers' engagement in research. They require external support while they are beginning researchers, but as they gain recognition and expertise, they start a phase where internal motivations outweigh external ones (Banegas, 2018). The other important factor was the lack of

time. This result is in line with many previous studies. For instance, Doqaruni et al. (2019) suggest that the degree to which teachers really participate in AR may depend more on time than on other factors. Borg (2007, 2008, 2009) also found in his series of surveys on teachers' involvement in research that time constraints were by far the most common reason given for not doing research. The other main reason was that lack of knowledge of research was assessed as a barrier by teachers. This finding is consistent with that of Banegas (2018), who indicated that the lack of knowledge is due to limited chances to attend conferences and engage in research. A possible explanation for this might be that the majority of teachers do not attend action research training courses and do not receive promotion or rewards for doing action research, as well as the lack of reading published research.

## Conclusion

This study aimed at determining teachers' perceptions of their school culture in relation to doing action research and the challenges faced them in conducting it. This is the first paper to examine English language teachers' conceptions about doing action research in Saudi Arabia.

This result can help supervisors and managers encourage teachers to conduct action research, which will solve teaching problems in classrooms. This suggests that teachers need many training courses related to action research and raising awareness among teachers of the practical contributions action research can make to develop their teaching. In order to provide helpful professional development workshops or sessions, it is advised that the institution conduct a needs analysis to fully understand teachers' challenges with doing action research.

As described above, our study was limited to a small number of participants; it was only conducted in one city and involved only English teachers at general schools. Future inquiries should include perceptions from different stakeholders in a greater geographical area to enrich the findings. In addition, this research focused on conducting action research individually; as a result, participatory action research needs to be studied. Finally, it applied a quantitative approach. Studies that use a mixed

approach and employ more data tools, for example, interviews, may provide a more comprehensive picture regarding teachers' perceptions of conducting action research.



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